But beyond the power ambitions of Mr Orbán or Mr Kaczyński, it would be essential to look beneath the surface of these governments' opposition to certain aspects of liberal democracy. The fact is that a lot of that opposition from the populist right has come as a result of the so-called 'cancel' culture, where dissent to some of the values, associated with liberal democracy, is not tolerated and not listened to – and not only in Eastern Europe. 'With some justification, it has been argued that the college campus – especially in the English-speaking world – is no longer reliably a gymnasium of the mind and has become, to a greater or lesser extent, a forcing house for various social justice causes that […] threaten the core purpose of higher education as the rigorous transmission of truth, knowledge, expertise and the skills of dispassionate inquiry.'[203] In such an environment, far from being limited to academia, it can easily happen that a diverging opinion 'is so obnoxious that is not *like* violence but *actually* violence. You cannot speak unless I feel "safe" in every sense of the word. If I cannot actually censor you, I will seek to drive you out of the public space by "cancelling" you.' d'Ancona cites the notorious example of the cancelling campaign against J.K. Rowling which happened in the wider public arena.[204]

In addition to basic human rights and freedoms, multi-party democracy, and the checks and balances essential for a functioning democracy, European values now often seem to be reduced to what Chin called 'sexual democracy'. A proof of this seems to be President Macron's call in January 2022 for abortion to be added to the EU Charter of Fundamental Rights, apparently to counter the moves by the Polish government to narrow down the grounds for abortion. Equally problematic are the occasional statements or pieces of legislation in Poland and Hungary in relation to the LGBT+ community that many found discriminating or at least insulting.

As for abortion in Europe, it was by and large decriminalised and/or legalised against the backdrop of feminist demands that saw in abortion a way out from women's oppressive submission to male will and desperate social or health circumstances. In the absence of modern contraceptives, the right to abortion was seen as personal, social and economic liberation. But a century later, with full female empowerment in the Western world, easy access to divorce, free pre- and post-natal care, paid maternity leave, economic and social emancipation of women and availability of (free of charge) contraceptives, these early twentieth-century grounds for abortion